SPORTS

CRICKET

THE BABY BOSS

VAIBHAV SOORYAVANSHI, THE 15-YEAR-OLD FROM BIHAR, WAS THE STORY OF IPL 2026, REWRITING THE RULES OF THE T20 FORMAT AND TAKING IT IN A NEW, HEADY DIRECTION

BY AMITABH SRIVASTAVA

776
Runs in 16 innings in IPL 2026, at an avg. of 48.50; wins Orange Cap for most runs

72
Sixes hit this IPL—the most in a single season



PTI

A week after his blistering 175 off 80 balls against England powered India to the Under-19 World Cup title in February, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi quietly sat out his CBSE Class 10 board exams in Samastipur, Bihar. With cricket consuming nearly all of his time and energy, Vaibhav had scarcely been able to devote time to academics. In much of small-town Bihar, where the old doctrine that one should at least clear matriculation—*10th pass karna hi chahiye*—still holds, the decision raised more than a few eyebrows.

It does not bother father Sanjeev Sooryavanshi, who runs a jewellery business. You just have to call him to find out why. Sanjeev's ringback tune is a line from a Manna Dey song in the 1969 film *Ek Phool, Do Mali*—'*Mera naam karega roshan jag mein mera raj dulara*', about a son making his father proud. In the Sooryavanshi household, though, it sounds less like nostalgia and more like conviction. Indeed, Vaibhav